

valuable as being handed a free check each month! Receiving money is always great, but making it last is another topic all together. Knowing how to hold on to what you've got is everything. That is why I believe it's important to educate yourselves on tax credits. There are tax credits out there that some of you don't know about, and this is a case where what you don't know *will* hurt you. It is wasteful to put dollars and dollars of your hard-earned money into something that isn't necessary. You could be using that money to pay off all your debt!

This is a gold mine that no one talks about. You can hold onto significant sums of money by way of these tax credits. A tax credit is not an expense that lowers your taxable income. A tax credit is actually tax dollars that you do not pay – tax dollars that stay in your pocket and do not get mailed off to Uncle Sam.

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It is easy, yet so many people assume that a tax credit is only for somebody else, somebody with “connections.” Not true. Want \$500? You can get money for making improvements to your house. By becoming more energy efficient – replacing old windows, updating your furnace, or putting new insulation in your home – you can get up to \$500. Not a bad deal. Saving energy is good for the planet and your pocketbook.

If you convert to a solar energy system to heat your water, you can get a tax credit of up to \$2000! That is \$2000 in taxes that you do not have to pay – that equals free money! If you buy a new hybrid kind of car – a part gas/part electric, or one that runs on an alternative fuel like ethanol, or even a diesel car – you can get a tax credit, up to \$4000! There is a formula that is used to compute the credit for energy efficient cars; the IRS or your car dealer can help you determine what the exact credit would be for your car.

For more information on all these energy credits, go to www.energystar.gov.

There are many tax credits that people do not know exist, and therefore they do not claim them. If you claim all the credits you are entitled to, you may be able to wipe out up to 80% of your tax bill!